An Explainable, Verifiable Platform for Disaster Aid Request, Tracking and Distribution in Sri Lanka: Design and Multi-Method Evaluation

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***Abstract*—Disaster relief in Sri Lanka is still coordinated largely through phone calls and social media, which makes it hard to see which needs are outstanding, how requests are prioritised, and whether donated goods arrive. Existing platforms address parts of this problem, but few combine open request intake, an inspectable prioritisation rule and verified delivery. Following design science research, we built a web and mobile platform for victims, donors, volunteers and administrators that pairs a disclosed rule-based priority score with priority-first donation matching, a single-use QR handover check and a public, aggregated dashboard. We evaluated the artefact with automated and security-rule tests, concurrent-load tests, a synthetic allocation simulation, and a nine-person usability pilot. In simulation, priority-first matching served almost all critical needs (99.6% vs. about 79% for first-come or nearest-first rules) but left most low-severity needs unmet (37% vs. 78%), and its distance tie-break decided 72% of matches. Testing led to two fixes: matching now runs in a database transaction, and a cache-stampede defect was removed (p95 about 11 s to 2.4 s). The pilot gave a mean System Usability Scale score of 91.1 (95% CI 84.5–97.7). The platform supports more transparent coordination, but its effect on equitable, timely distribution in a real disaster remains unmeasured.**

***Index Terms*—disaster management, humanitarian logistics, aid prioritisation, explainable decision rules, delivery verification, design science research, Sri Lanka**

I. Introduction

Sri Lanka faces recurrent floods, landslides and cyclones. The May–June 2024 floods affected more than 235,000 people [1], and Cyclone Ditwah in late 2025 caused 646 deaths, left 173 missing and affected between 1.2 and 2.2 million people across all 25 districts (the situation report gives both figures) [2], [3], with damage estimated at US$4.1 billion, about 4% of GDP [4].

Studies of Sri Lankan disaster response describe coordination through phone calls, social media and manual records in the health sector [5] and limited cross-agency collaboration in flood response [6]. Humanitarian-logistics research shows that, without shared information, relief tends to favour accessible areas [7] and that unsolicited donations create "material convergence" that burdens responders [8]. During Cyclone Ditwah, a volunteer platform received about 200 SOS requests representing more than 10,000 people within hours of launch [9], [10], which indicates strong demand for a structured channel.

We ask: *how can a centralised aid request, tracking and distribution system support transparency, coordination and efficiency in Sri Lankan disaster relief?* The contributions are: (1) a four-role web and mobile artefact with explicit design principles; (2) a disclosed allocation rule, analysed for sensitivity, starvation and distance feasibility through simulation; (3) a delivery-verification protocol with a stated threat model; and (4) a multi-method evaluation whose limits are reported alongside its results.

II. Related Work

A. Coordination Platforms

Sahana was developed in Sri Lanka after the 2004 tsunami. It provides organisation, camp and people registries and a request-management module that matches pledges of assistance to requests [11], but it was not adopted nationally in later Sri Lankan floods [12]. Ushahidi-style crowdsourcing surfaces needs quickly [13], and crisis informatics has since added social-media analytics and machine classification of messages [14], [15], but such tools suffer from duplicate and mislocated reports [16] and stop at situational awareness. FloodSupport.org, built during Cyclone Ditwah, collected SOS reports through the web and SMS in three languages [9], [10], but its verification and prioritisation methods are not published. AidTrack [17] verifies pre-registered households with QR codes within one municipality and does not disclose its AI-assisted prioritisation. The official channels of the national Disaster Management Centre (DMC) focus on warnings and situation reports [18].

B. Allocation, Equity and Explainability

Relief allocation balances efficiency, efficacy and equity [19], [7], and last-mile distribution models make explicit how scarce supplies are rationed between locations [20]. Optimisation models need data and operators that are rarely available in community-level response. Interest in explainable AI in disaster risk management reflects the difficulty of justifying opaque scores to affected people [21]. Blockchain-based donation tracking makes a transaction traceable once a match has been made but leaves the matching decision open [22].

Table I compares named systems on stated criteria. Sahana already integrates requests and pledges. The gap we address is therefore narrower than a missing integrated platform: an *inspectable* prioritisation rule, *verified* handover and *public* aggregate reporting, combined in a mobile-first tool for the Sri Lankan setting.

TABLE I
COMPARISON OF NAMED SYSTEMS

Criterion	Sahana	Ushahidi	FloodSup.	AidTrack	Ours
Open request intake	✓	✓	✓	×	✓
Donation/pledge matching	✓	×	?	P	✓
Published priority rule	×	×	×	×	✓
Volunteer dispatch	P	×	P	×	✓
Verified handover	×	×	?	✓	✓
Public aggregate dashboard	×	✓	?	P	✓
Native mobile app	×	✓	×	×	✓

✓ = documented in the cited source; P = partial (a related feature exists but does not meet the criterion in full); ? = not documented; × = documented as absent or out of scope. Assessed from [11], [13], [10], [17].

III. METHOD

We followed design science research [23] using the six DSRM phases [24]. In Gregor and Hevner's terms [25], the contribution is an *improvement*: a new solution to a known problem. Four design principles guided the artefact: **DP1** every allocation decision can be traced to disclosed inputs; **DP2** a delivery closes only with evidence produced at handover; **DP3** public views show aggregates only, never personal data; **DP4** every write passes server-side business rules. Requirements came from secondary sources and the comparison in Section II, giving 33 functional requirements (FR-01 to FR-33). No domain experts were consulted, which is a threat to validity (Section VI-A).

The evaluation followed the FEDS "technical risk and efficacy" strategy [26]: artificial evaluation first (unit, integration and security-rule tests, load tests, simulation), then a small naturalistic usability pilot. Participation was voluntary and anonymised, with written consent. [Ethics: state approval body and reference number, or exemption.]

IV. DESIGN

A. Architecture

Fig. 1 shows the layers. React (web) and Expo/React Native (mobile) clients call one Node.js/Express API, which enforces role middleware and all business rules. Firestore and Firebase Authentication store data. Clients may *read* live data through Firestore listeners, but every *write* goes through the API (DP4), and Firestore security rules repeat the role and ownership checks. External services provide hazard feeds (DMC, GDACS, USGS, Irrigation Department gauges), routing, and parallel push (FCM) and SMS notifications. The API runs as serverless functions on Vercel.

B. Priority Rule

Each request r is scored at submission:

$$S(r) = w_{\text{sev}}(r) + \min(2n_r, 30) + 5v_r + \min(1.5h_r, 20), \quad (1)$$

where $w_{\text{sev}} \in \{40, 30, 20, 10\}$ (critical to low), n_r is the number of people affected, $v_r \le 4$ counts vulnerable groups (children, elderly, pregnant women, people with disabilities) and h_r is hours waited. Three points need stating. (i) The vulnerable term reaches at most 20, so the cap of 25 in the code never applies. (ii) The score is computed once, when $h_r \approx 0$, so waiting time does not yet affect rank; the rule effectively has *three* active criteria and ranges from 10 to 90. (iii) The people term saturates at 15 people, so a household of 15 and a village of 1,500 score the same. The weights were set by the designers and are not taken from Sphere standards or DMC guidance. Section V-C tests their sensitivity.

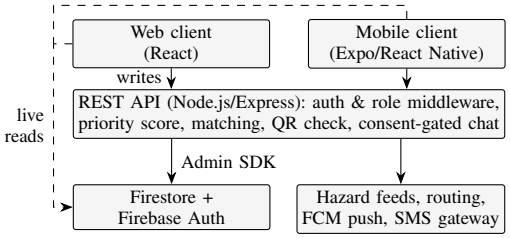


Fig. 1. Architecture. Solid arrows: requests through the API, the only write path. Dashed: read-only Firestore listeners, constrained by security rules.

Algorithm 1 Priority-First Matching (Deployed)

Require: donation d: category c, location ℓ_d, remainder q_d

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C ← pending items of category c in verified requests
sort C by S(r) desc., then Haversine(ℓ_d, ℓ_r) asc.
if C = ∅ then
    return no match
end if
for all (r, i) ∈ C in order do
    in a transaction: re-read i and q_d; if i is still pending and q_d > 0, mark i matched, set q_d ← q_d − min(q_d, need_i) and stop
end for
create delivery; self-delivery is auto-accepted, otherwise assign the nearest available volunteer (ties: fewest active deliveries)
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C. Matching and Assignment

Algorithm 1 picks the highest-scoring verified request item in the donation's category and uses Haversine distance only to break ties. Each match consumes the smaller of the donation's remainder and the item's need. Volunteers are ranked by distance to pickup and then by active workload. Siblings from one multi-item drop-off are kept with the same volunteer where possible. Each match runs inside a Firestore transaction that re-reads the item and the donation's remainder before writing. If a concurrent match has already taken the item, the next-best candidate is tried, so two matches cannot claim the same item or spend the same balance (Section V-B).

D. Handover Check and Threat Model

When a delivery is marked *delivered*, the server issues a single-use 128-bit token. The token is shown as a QR code only to the party holding the goods and is removed from the victim's API responses. The server confirms the delivery only if the caller owns the request and the token matches; otherwise it returns HTTP 403. This prevents (a) one-sided confirmation

TABLE II
REQUIREMENT EVIDENCE BY FEATURE AREA

Area	FRs	Formal test	Dev. check only	Not tested
A Intake & administration	01–07	6	1	0
B Donation & delivery	08–14	5	1	1 (FR-11)
C Maps & forecasting	15–19	3	2	0
D Emergency oversight	20–24	2	3	0
E Engagement & platforms	25–30	3	3	0
F Inventory & coordination	31–33	2	1	0
Total	33	21	11	1

by a deliverer, (b) confirmation of someone else's delivery and (c) guessing the token. It does *not* prove that goods physically changed hands. A photographed QR code could be relayed remotely, and a colluding victim and volunteer can confirm a delivery that never happened. We therefore treat the scan as evidence of handover (DP2), not proof, and recommend audit sampling. Self-reported severity and vulnerability can also be inflated. Mitigations are administrator verification, duplicate flags on NIC number or address, and an append-only audit log. Verification approves or rejects a request but does not adjust its score, which leaves a gap.

E. Privacy and Other Safeguards

NIC numbers, addresses and exact locations are visible only to their owner and to administrators. Public endpoints return district aggregates (DP3), in line with Sri Lanka's Personal Data Protection Act, No. 9 of 2022 [27]. People without an NIC, such as children or undocumented people, cannot be checked for duplicates by NIC. The SOS module is a supplementary channel and links users to the official DMC 117 hotline [28]. It does not replace official dispatch and has not been evaluated in a real emergency.

An auxiliary, separately evaluated flood-risk layer (a logistic regression trained on DesInventar and NASA POWER data) is shown on the maps. It never affects allocation.

V. EVALUATION

A. Verification and Traceability

Table II maps the 33 FRs to the strongest evidence available for each. Twenty-one FRs have a passing formal test case, eleven were checked only live during development, and FR-11 (rejection reopening a donation) is implemented but was not separately tested. Evidence for FR-12 is partial because the camera round trip could not be exercised. Evidence for FR-27 is partial because on-device push delivery was not observed. Evidence for FR-30 is partial because the mobile app compiles and runs, but its maps and push notifications have not been verified on a physical device. The automated suites passed 77/77 unit tests, 48/48 API checks across 14 route files and 45/45 direct Firestore security-rule checks. The rule tests found an over-broad read rule on deliveries, which was corrected and re-verified.

B. Concurrency and Performance

A script created 76 accounts and sent concurrent requests to a single local API instance backed by cloud Firestore. In a race probe, 30 donations competed for the same 30 items. Early versions read candidates and wrote without a transaction, a classic lost-update pattern for a partial-quantity balance. No double allocation was observed then, but that showed only that the race had not been triggered. Matching was therefore moved into a transaction (Section IV-C). After the change, the probe again produced zero double allocations, now guaranteed by the transaction rather than by timing. Every HTTP request succeeded in the later runs. One volunteer-acceptance step was skipped by the test harness because a delivery had been assigned to a non-test account, which shows the harness needs better test isolation. Mean latency per phase was 0.9–8.4 s, and concurrent matching was slowest (p95 about 9.1 s before the transaction change; [post-change p95 from your latest run]).

The dashboard statistics endpoints scanned whole collections on every call, giving a p95 of about 11 s for 50 concurrent reads. A 30 s cache made this worse (p95 about 25 s) because concurrent cache misses each started their own scan, a cache stampede. Caching the in-flight promise (a single-flight pattern) reduced p95 to about 2.4 s, compared with the original uncached 11 s. The remaining 2.4 s is the cost of one full scan on a cold cache. The cache is held in memory, so on serverless hosting each new instance starts cold and instances do not share results. Precomputed aggregate documents or Firestore count queries would remove the scans. A third back-to-back run slowed markedly. We suspect Firebase rate limiting after repeated account creation, but this was not verified.

C. Allocation Simulation and Sensitivity

To cover the scenario demonstration (DSRM phase 4), we simulated a 72-hour response with 3,000 requests. Requests were placed by districts' historical flood frequency from DesInventar. Supply was 70% of demand, 60% of donors were in Colombo, Gampaha and Kandy, and matching ran hourly. We ran 30 seeds and compared the deployed rule with first-in-first-out (FIFO), nearest-first and random matching, and with two variants: aging, which re-scores with the wait term each cycle, and a 100 km distance cap. The simulation models allocation only, not travel or delivery. Table III reports the results.

Priority-first matching (Fig. 2) gave critical needs near-complete and fast service. Low-severity needs, however, were mostly left unmet (37% vs. 78%), confirming the risk of starvation. Aging with the current 20-point wait cap did not fix this (38%), because the cap is smaller than the 30-point severity gap between critical and low, and it delayed critical items. Any aging scheme therefore needs a larger or uncapped wait term. Distance broke ties in 72% of matches, and 28% of matches were more than 150 km apart, which is impractical for self-delivery. Nearest-first matching shortened distances but served the worst district only 29% of the time. A 100 km cap halved mean distance but lowered equity across districts (Gini

TABLE III
SIMULATED ALLOCATION (MEAN OF 30 SEEDS; SD ≤ 0.03 FOR RATES)

Policy	Crit. served	Low served	Crit. wait (h, med.)	Mean km	Gini	Worst district
Priority (deployed)	.996	.371	1.3	115	.027	.70
FIFO	.787	.783	28.8	140	.027	.71
Nearest-first	.785	.785	16.5	41	.178	.29
Random	.787	.785	19.7	140	.022	.72
Priority + aging	.994	.379	6.0	123	.027	.70
Priority + 100 km	.982	.493	3.3	63	.127	.43

Overall item fulfilment was 0.78–0.79 for every policy, so supply sets how much is delivered and the policy sets who receives it. "Served" = share of items matched within 72 h. Gini = Gini coefficient of district fulfilment ratios; Worst district = lowest district fulfilment ratio.

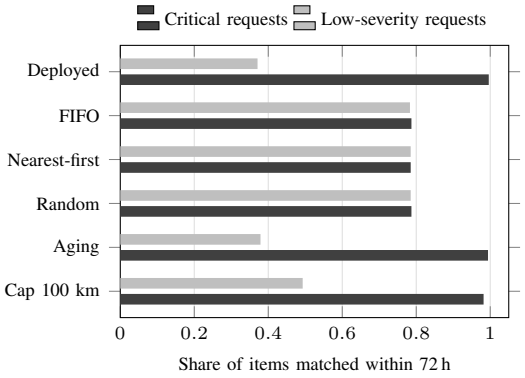


Fig. 2. Simulated service by severity (30 seeds; Deployed = priority-first; Aging and Cap 100 km are priority-first variants). Priority-first serves critical needs at the expense of low-severity ones; capped aging does not close the gap.

0.127). This trade-off between feasibility and equity matches [19].

For sensitivity, we varied each weight by ±25–50% on 15,000 synthetic requests. Kendall's τ against the baseline ranking stayed at or above 0.83, and overlap in the top 10% stayed at or above 0.79. In 1,000 joint random perturbations, the median τ was 0.90 (5th percentile 0.80). The score took only 73 distinct values, so ties are pervasive. Replacing the people term with $\min(10 \log_{10}(1 + n_r), 30)$, which saturates near 1,000 people, changed rankings more than any weight change ($\tau = 0.78$, top-10% overlap 0.61). How the people term is scaled is therefore the most consequential open choice and should be checked against expert rankings.

D. Flood-Risk Layer

In-sample, the model scored AUC-ROC 0.825, with recall of only 12.4% at a 0.5 threshold. For a temporal hold-out (training 1981–2010, testing 2011–2019, district rate computed from training years only), climatology baselines reached AUC 0.687 (district×month) and 0.720 (month only), with Brier scores of 0.123 and 0.121 against 0.128 for a constant. The model scored AUC [X] and Brier [X]. DesInventar reporting grows sharply after 2002 and almost stops in 2020: the test-period positive rate is 0.146, against 0.087 in training. This reporting bias limits calibration, so the layer is presented as a ranking aid, not a warning tool.

E. Usability Pilot

Nine participants (2 victim, 3 donor, 2 volunteer and 2 administrator roles), all students and acquaintances recruited by convenience, completed scripted think-aloud scenarios with seeded accounts in [session language(s)]. The developer facilitated, read each task aloud and performed back-end steps (e.g., matching) where a scenario required them. A task counted as "unaided" when no help was recorded for any of its steps. The SUS score [29] had a mean of 91.1 (SD 8.6, 95% CI 84.5–97.7, range 80–100) [30]. All tasks were completed, with six errors in total. Per-role SUS and Cronbach's α are not reported because $n \leq 3$ per role. No participant was a DMC or NGO worker or a Sinhala- or Tamil-speaking affected person. Social desirability and familiarity with the developer probably inflated scores. Three participants criticised the density and font sizes of the mobile interface.

VI. DISCUSSION

Research question. The artefact *supports* transparency and coordination: allocations can be traced to disclosed inputs (DP1), handovers leave verifiable evidence (DP2), and aggregate status is public (DP3). It does not yet show improved efficiency or equity. The simulation instead shows that a disclosed priority rule makes its trade-offs visible, including starvation of low-severity needs and long matching distances, so they can be debated and tuned. That visibility is the main practical value of an explainable rule. Compared with Sahana [11], the added value lies in the published rule, the handover check and public aggregates. It does not lie in integration itself.

Engineering lesson. Single-flight caching avoids stampedes but, on serverless hosting, should be backed by precomputed aggregates.

A. Threats to Validity

Internal: the load tests ran against one local instance, not the serverless deployment, and the test harness was not fully isolated from real accounts. The usability sessions were facilitated by the developer. *External:* the simulation's inputs (severity mix, donor concentration, supply ratio) are assumptions. The usability sample is small and unrepresentative, and the rule weights are not validated by experts. *Construct:* "served" measures allocation, not delivered aid. SUS measures perceived usability, not coordination outcomes. Flood labels record reported incidents, not floods that occurred. *Coverage:* the platform needs connectivity and a smartphone. SMS is outbound only; there is no USSD, call-centre or offline QR fallback. Sinhala and Tamil strings are machine-translated and unreviewed, per-request scoring treats water and clothing as equally urgent, and every request waits for manual administrator verification, which becomes a bottleneck in a surge unless verification is delegated to district officers.

VII. Conclusion

We presented a disaster-aid platform for Sri Lanka built on explicit design principles and evaluated with complementary methods. The disclosed rule served critical needs quickly. Simulation exposed its starvation and distance costs, and testing led to transactional matching and a fix for a cache stampede. Future work comprises: uncapped aging; a distance-feasibility threshold and category-specific urgency; validation of the weights through expert ranking with DMC and NGO staff; offline and SMS intake; held-out model validation; and a larger, representative usability study before any field pilot.

Data availability: code, test scripts and simulation inputs are available at [anonymised repository link].

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